

MARKETING SWEET · ROLEPLAY 03

The Accountability Conversation

Session tie-in: Session 03 — Obsession is the Multiplier, Balance is the Scam

Difficulty: Hard · **Run time:** ~20 min · **Reps required:** 2

The setup

You're a senior rep at Marketing Sweet. You've been given operator-level responsibility for a small team. **One of your team members has had a rough six weeks** — closing rate down, missed quota two months running. You're sitting down with them for a 1:1.

Their name's Riley. Six months ago Riley was one of the strongest reps on the floor. Three months ago numbers started slipping. Six weeks ago Corie flagged it. You've watched Riley start to lean on excuses: "market's tough", "leads are weaker than last quarter", "the new ATS is slowing me down".

You like Riley. You don't want this to be a confrontation — but you can't let it slide either. The lesson from Session 03 is direct: results, not effort. Excuses are reasons in disguise. The only allowed next thought is one specific behaviour change.

You are the operator. Riley walks in.

Coaching note — before you start: This is the hardest roleplay in the set. The whole point of Session 03 was the leadership handover — senior reps are now operators of the business. That means you don't wait for Corie to have this conversation. You have it.

THE SCRIPT

OPERATOR: Hey mate, take a seat. Want to talk to you about the last six weeks.

RILEY: Yeah, I figured. Numbers haven't been there. Look, leads have been weaker, the new ATS is —

OPERATOR: Mate. Stop. Before you go anywhere with that — I want one minute, no excuses, no reasons. Just the numbers. Six weeks ago you were sitting at a 38% close rate. Last month: 22%. This month so far: 18%. Yeah?

RILEY: Yeah, that's about right.

OPERATOR: I'm not interested in how hard you're working. I know you're working hard. The question is what's changed in your daily routine since six weeks ago that's not running anymore.

Coaching note: That's the Session 03 line, verbatim — "I'm not interested in how hard you work. I'm interested in whether you're achieving the results." Lead with results. Don't open with empathy, because empathy here gives Riley permission to externalise.

RILEY: *[Pauses. Looks uncomfortable.]* Yeah I mean, the leads have been —

OPERATOR: Mate. I'll stop you again. Leads are the same leads. Same source, same intake quality. We can run the numbers if you want — I checked this morning. The volume's actually up 8% on six weeks ago. Whatever's changed isn't on the input side.

Coaching note: You've now removed his external scapegoat — politely but firmly. You showed data. He can't blame leads with a straight face anymore. He'll either lean on a different excuse or start to own it.

RILEY: *[Long pause.]* Yeah. Look. I haven't been as prepped going into pitches. I used to do the full research thing — competitor check, monthly turnover estimate, jobs per day. Last six weeks I've been winging it.

OPERATOR: Why?

RILEY: *[Shrugs.]* I dunno, mate. Got comfortable. Started cutting corners on prep because it was working without it. Then it stopped working.

Coaching note: That's the honest sentence — and it's the only sentence that leads to a different outcome. Notice you got there fast: by refusing the first two excuses, you forced him to land on the real one. Don't celebrate it. Move straight to the fix.

OPERATOR: Okay. Good — that's the conversation. Two questions. One: what specifically are you going to change tomorrow? Not "I'll prep more." A specific thing. What are you going to do *first* before any pitch this week.

RILEY: Pull the prospect's turnover estimate, jobs per day, and main competitor before I walk in. Like before.

OPERATOR: Two: how am I going to know you've done it?

RILEY: Uh — I dunno. I just will. You'll see the close rate come back.

OPERATOR: Not good enough, mate. "I'll just do it" is what got us here. Every Friday between now and end of the month — five minutes with me, run me through the three numbers for every pitch you've got booked for the following week. I'm not micromanaging you. I'm helping you reinstall the habit until it's back to reflex. Sound fair?

RILEY: Yeah. Fair enough.

OPERATOR: One more thing — the invisible competition. Somewhere right now there's a rep working twice as hard as you, with no plan B, treating obsession as survival. They want your seat. They want your commissions. They're not waiting for the leads to get better. Don't compete with the rep at the next desk — compete with them. Got it?

RILEY: Got it.

OPERATOR: Good. See you Friday with the numbers.

Coaching note: The whole conversation took ~3 minutes of script time. It works because (a) you led with data, not feelings, (b) you refused the first two excuses without being aggressive, (c) you locked in a specific habit change with a specific accountability mechanism, and (d) you closed with the invisible-competition framing to reset the mindset. No motivation talk. No “you’ve got this.” Discipline isn’t built with pep — it’s built with structure.

THE FORK — Riley pushes back harder:

RILEY: Mate, with respect — you’re not in my shoes. The leads I’m getting *are* different. I’m not making this up.

Coaching note: This is a real test. Riley could be right — sometimes lead quality genuinely shifts. Sometimes it’s an excuse. You need to handle this without becoming the boss who doesn’t listen.

OPERATOR: Okay. Fair point. If the leads are different, that’s something we should fix at the source — let’s pull the lead quality data together right now. Five minutes. Then we’ll know if there’s actually a lead problem or if there’s something on the rep side. Either way, we’re closer to fixing it. Cool?

Coaching note: You didn’t dismiss him. You said “let’s look at the data together.” Either the data backs him up (and you now have a real problem to fix on the lead-gen side) or it doesn’t (and his excuse just collapsed under verification). You win either way.

STRETCH VARIATIONS

- **Riley’s actually right about the leads.** Pull the data, find the lead-quality drop, raise it with Corie. You haven’t failed Riley — you’ve found a real problem. The accountability still applies on the bit Riley controls.
 - **Riley gets defensive and emotional.** Slow down. Step back. Acknowledge the difficulty. But don’t drop the standard. End with the same specific habit ask.
 - **Riley is one of the senior reps and you’re the same level.** Reframe as a peer accountability conversation, not manager-to-rep. The technique still works — facts first, real cause, specific behaviour change.
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WHAT TO LOOK FOR WHEN YOU’RE PRACTISING THIS

- Did the operator hold the line on “I’m interested in results, not effort”?
- Did they refuse the first two excuses without becoming aggressive?

- Did they let Riley reach the honest sentence himself, or did they bulldoze him into it?
- Did they lock in a *specific* habit change, or did they accept a vague “I’ll do better”?
- Did they end with an accountability mechanism (Friday check-in) or just trust that it would happen?

This is a leadership skill, not a sales skill. Expect it to feel uncomfortable the first three times. That’s the point — feeling-bad is the signal you’re doing it right.